

Contending for the Faith

Open up to the book of Jude, and let us lay a foundation beginning with verse 3:

Beloved, when I gave all diligence
to write unto you of the common salvation,
it was needful for me to write unto you,
and exhort you that ye should earnestly contend
for the faith which was once delivered unto the saints.

Verse 4 says:

For there are certain men crept in unawares.

You remind me of me when I first got turned on to the fact that there is a deliberate, premeditated, on-purpose way to walk into the power of God.

I was so hungry. It was not enough for me to know that you could walk in power. The cry of my heart was, "For God's sake, can somebody tell me how?"

It is not enough to know that I can. Somebody please tell me how.

Can you imagine how I felt when I found the passage that said, "Roberson, you should earnestly contend for the kind of faith the early saints walked in"?

Somebody said, "You are in the faith move."

I said, "Yes, sir."

"You know we already have more than the early church had."

I beg your pardon. Nobody is writing the Bible now. You have to at least have as much before you can have more. I did not notice people lined up outside on the street just in case our shadow fell on them when we got here, did you? Nor did I notice ambulances making one-way trips to this meeting.

Yet that kind of power is available.

When I found the verse that said we should earnestly contend for that devil-stomping, mountain-moving kind of faith the early church walked in, I knew one thing about the Word of God: it will not tell me to contend for that kind of faith without going on in detail to tell me how.

It is not enough to know that I should. For God's sake, would somebody tell me how?

Do not wave the steak in front of my face and not give it to me.

Jude would not tell you and me to earnestly contend without going on to tell us how.

Jude said certain men crept in unawares. Whoever these men were, they literally destroyed the faith of the early church.

I studied these men, if for no other reason than to find out what I should not do if I do not want to lose my walk of faith.

Jude likened these men who destroyed the faith of the early church to waves of the sea, foaming, raging to their own shame. These waves came up out of the sea and put on quite a show, but just as quickly as they came into existence, they disappeared back into the body they came out of.

He likened them to wandering stars. You and I call them shooting stars. They come into existence with a blaze of glory, but just as quickly, they disappear into the darkness they came out of.

By far my favorite label is:

clouds without water.

What is a cloud without water? When it comes over the horizon, it looks real good and puts on quite a show. But when it comes time to produce, it cannot, because it has no water.

From Genesis to Revelation, God has always likened the Holy Spirit to water.

Jesus said:

He that believeth on me,
as the scripture hath said,
out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water.

What is the first criterion for this walk of power? I cannot be a cloud without water. I must be that cloud with water.

Again, Jude would not tell me to earnestly contend for that kind of faith without going on, before the teaching is even over, to tell me how.

Jude 19 says:

These be they who separate themselves,
sensual,
having not the Spirit.

Who are the "they" he is talking about? They are the clouds without water.

Notice the label he put on them. He said they are sensual, or sense-ruled, having not the Spirit.

Now think about this. If us faith people had a creed, what would it be?

In modern-day religion, a faith person is someone who chews a whole lot of Copenhagen. That is to say, they devour a lot of Copeland and Hagin tapes.

If we had a creed, it would probably be:

"I am not moved by what I see, hear, or feel. I am only moved by what I believe, and I take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life."

"But preacher, you are sick."

Who asked you?

"Just ask your body. It will tell you."

Of course it will tell me. That is the way my senses are designed. If anything goes wrong, my body starts prophesying: "Roberson, you are getting sick."

Am I going to ask my body? No. I am going to ask the Word of God as the final say-so in my life, because it declares:

Himself took our infirmities,
and bare our sicknesses.

Glory to God, I do not have to have mine.

We are saying we are not dominated by our senses. We are not ruled by what we see, hear, or feel. We take the Word of God as the final say-so in our lives.

In light of Jude 19, he is saying, "We are not like these clouds without water who do not have the Holy Spirit." Because we have the Holy Ghost, we do not have to be sensual or sense-dominated.

But I have news for you. The Holy Ghost has a much bigger part to play in your life than you thought when you are walking out of being dominated by your senses and into the place in the Spirit where He has declared you free.

He says we are not like these clouds without water, sense-ruled. Why? Because we have the Holy Ghost.

When I first got turned on to Copeland and Hagin as a young preacher, I was an ultra-Pentecostal holiness preacher.

This is the kind of thing we lived on: "If you are in a movie show when the rapture takes place, do not worry. You will have plenty of time to finish your movie. If you are wearing jewelry, you will have to stay and finish paying for it. Watch those earrings. Those are the devil's stirrups. What do you think he mounts your mind with?"

That was my diet.

We dressed people from the outside in. We wanted them to effect change, but we would not give them anything to do it with.

They told me, "If you had anything, you would quit smoking that pipe."

I thought, "My God, if they would give me anything, I would."

I am still praising and thanking God for the day He taught me the laws of meditation. The Word of God is the most powerful force on the face of this earth. There is a way in the Holy Ghost to approach this Word where it comes so alive in you that it not only makes the devil sick, it drives every damnable disease out of your body.

I found out that Jude 19 and 20 were one thought. They were not meant to be separated. When I found that out, I took my first step into the greatest freedom I have ever known.

Jude 20 says:

But ye, beloved,
building up yourselves
on your most holy faith,
praying in the Holy Ghost.

As much as I had striven for faith, bawled for faith, threatened the mountain, threatened God, and cried through fits, it all did no good. Under my nose was a verse that said:

But ye, beloved,
building up yourselves on your most holy faith,
praying in the Holy Ghost.

I thought, "God, build myself up where? Where am I going?"

I asked one preacher, and he said, "Well, it means you are edified."

Of course it means that. But what is it actually talking about?

When I realized both verses were one thought, I saw it. You do not have to be sense-ruled or sense-dominated like a man who does not have the Holy Spirit, because you have the Holy Ghost.

Why do I not have to be sense-ruled anymore? Because He will build me up.

Up where?

Up above a walk where my senses bring me to a dead standstill, into a glorious, liberated walk of power by praying in the Holy Ghost.

Mark 11:23 says:

Whosoever shall say unto this mountain,
Be thou removed,
and be thou cast into the sea;
and shall not doubt in his heart,
but shall believe that those things which he saith shall come to pass;
he shall have whatsoever he saith.

It says if I doubt not in my heart, I could have whatsoever I say with my mouth.

Hold on. You mean if I come to the place in God where I do not doubt with my heart, then I can have what I say with my mouth?

Then thank God, we have found something we can do on purpose, just because we want to. It carries an ironclad guarantee to affect me in the very part of me where He said doubt must not be.

Praying in the Holy Ghost builds myself up where? Up above a walk dominated by my senses into a glorious, liberated walk of power in the Holy Ghost. It affects my spirit to edification and builds my spirit up higher and higher in God.

In these next days, we are going to progressively take one step at a time. If you go on failing, it is because you are going to have to walk to Him.

When I was that young ultra-Pentecostal holiness boy, I was so hungry for God it hurt. God had mercy on me and gave me a vision.

I woke up under an anointing. The power of God was all over me, and I could see it as clearly as I can see you. I saw a large auditorium. I was sitting on the left-hand side, and I knew by revelation it was my service. I was taking it over. My wife was sitting next to me.

There was a front man. He got ready to turn it over to me and said, "And now, our evangelist..."

I started to stand up. He looked at me for a moment, turned around, pointed at the curtain, and when he did, this young, beautiful woman floated out from behind the curtain. She got hold of the microphone, loved all over everybody, and emptied two or three wheelchairs.

When the service was over, she looked me right in the eye and said, "I do not know why God has given me this ministry. One of you men must have failed."

I died right then. I hurt so badly that when my wife woke up, I said, "Look, I cannot live the way I do anymore. I hurt too badly. Will you go with me?"

She said yes.

"To swim, sink, eat beans, sleep under a tree, dress the kids in gunny sacks, will you still go?"

She said yes.

Two weeks later, I found myself full-time. I did not know what to do with my time. I was a young ultra boy. As of yet, I had not been introduced to the Word of God as I know it now.

So I reported to the church. When the mill whistle blew, I was in position on my knees, ready to pray. I had no idea what praying in tongues would do. The only reason I prayed in tongues was to survive the hours I had committed to, because I figured that if I would pray the amount of time I would normally work, somehow God would pay me.

It was an eight-by-eight prayer closet. The first twenty minutes were English, because that was all I could think of to say. I prayed for the missionaries in India, cursed the cockroaches, asked God to put groceries in our cupboard, and cried for the anointing.

Then, just to survive the time I had committed to, I switched to praying in tongues.

After only fifteen minutes, I thought at least two hours had gone by. Finally, the ten o'clock mill whistle blew. That meant we could have our break. I had to beat it down to the coffee shop for donuts, run back, and be in position in fifteen minutes, ready for prayer again.

That went on week after week. I imprisoned myself in that closet because I did not know what else to do.

Some woman finally caught on to what I was doing and asked, "Are you feeling anything?"

I said, "Yes."

She said, "What?"

I said, "A tired chin, a tired mouth, and a dry throat."

About two months went by, and somebody bought me a whole box of Kenneth Hagin reel-to-reel tapes from when he preached three and four hours at a time. I got to listening to Hagin tapes, and that prayer and that Word started merging. Ultra mistakes started falling off.

Three months went by while I was still locked in my closet and hardly seeing anybody. A woman came running over and said, "Brother Roberson, there is a lay witness in town. We are all gathering together for the weekend in the church, and we wanted to know if you wanted to come."

This lay witness did not speak with tongues. They did not even like it. But she was a friend, and I thought, "Goody, goody gumdrops. This is a good reason to get out of the closet for a while."

So I ran home, changed, and went to the house where they had a morning prayer and Bible study. I got there late.

I did not know the woman sitting next to me had come in on a crutch. How could I know that? I was late.

I was excited because this man was going to teach a Bible study, and I had only been listening to tapes. This was my first real live service with real people all around me.

The teacher unrolled his notes on the floor and began: "And we know that Jesus is the great celestial go-between..."

I sat there thinking, "What did you get yourself into?" My mind floated in and out. I thought, "I would rather be in the closet."

I had no idea what was going to take place. I did not even know I was edifying myself.

Out of pure boredom, I turned and looked at the elderly lady next to me. When I did, it looked like somebody pulled an X-ray out of my spirit and stuck it up in my spirit's eye.

It was an X-ray of a hip. The hip had dark arthritis all around the ball joint, extending three to four inches down into the leg. The thing was suspended between me and her.

I almost dropped my coffee. I blinked, and it stayed there.

I said, "God, what do You want me to do?"

Silence.

It was almost as if, "If the vision is not enough, maybe I called the wrong guy."

I had just gotten hold of some tapes on decency and order, so I leaned over to the lady and said, "Ma'am, do you have arthritis in your right hip?"

She said, "Why, that is what the doctor tells me, young man."

I said, "Praise God."

She said, "I beg your pardon?"

I said, "God is going to heal you."

"Well, I know He is able."

I said, "I do too, but I mean He is going to. Can I pray for you?"

You have to understand, the orator was still reading. To her, prayer meant that in the course of her day, in a moment of silence, she would bow her head and remember someone. That is not what prayer meant to me. The only services I had ever been in were the ones where men jumped benches and spit cotton balls.

The harder you prayed and the louder, the more results you got.

She said, "Yes, you may, Sonny."

I jumped around in front of her, got down on my knees, grabbed both her ankles, and jerked them straight up even with my belly button. She slid down. One leg was four inches shorter.

I thought, "My God, look at this leg." I could not look, so I closed my eyes and proceeded to pray one of those strong, ultra-Pentecostal holiness prayers.

"In the name..."

Immediately, the golden-tongued orator launched his associate in our direction. It was too late. I had my eyes closed.

The witnesses told me that on the first "Jesus," all the arthritis left her leg. I did not know that. My eyes were closed.

The associate got there just in time to see the leg go. Instead of breaking it up, it struck him mute.

They tried to tell her she was not healed, but it did not do any good because she was beating them with her cane.

That afternoon at their luncheon, the woman stood up and said, "If He did it for me, He will do it for you."

There was a woman there under therapeutic care who could not bend over. They said, "Let us call Roberson."

They called and asked, "Can we come over?"

I started to say, "Bring everybody." But the Holy Spirit interrupted me and said, "You go down to the church."

I said, "I have to go to the church."

They were waiting for me out front. When I got there, they said, "We want to take you into a basement room that nobody knows anything about."

They were going to hide me down there and let me pray for them.

The Holy Spirit said, "No. Go to the main auditorium."

I said, "Main auditorium."

They waited for the break. At the break, they led me up front, and I was standing there thinking, "What do You want me to do next, God?"

They thought I was standing there to get everybody's attention. The orator's associate said, "I think he wants to say something."

I thought, "I do? I have never preached. What am I going to say?"

Everybody looked at me. I opened my mouth and started telling them what happened to the elderly woman. When I did, it felt like somebody threw a hydraulic jack under my spirit. I got caught in the hands of the Holy Spirit.

Something happened to me. I heard myself saying things and thought, "My God, man, you know you are not that smart." That is a good sign the Teacher has shown up.

It affected them the same way. They started creeping toward their chairs. As soon as they could, they sat down.

All of a sudden, a man's shoulder section became transparent like an X-ray. I ran over and said, "Your shoulder is going to be healed." I grabbed his wrist. He screamed. I jerked it straight up in the air, and he said, "My God, look at this."

Then the woman under therapeutic care could bend over and touch her toes. Then the boy with cataracts had them fall off onto his cheeks.

The elders moved into the crowd and said, "We have to break this up."

Before they could, I yelled, "Anyone want what I have?"

All the youth came running up and were getting filled with the Holy Ghost, speaking with tongues, out of control. They would fall, and the others would hold them up saying, "Are you all right?"

Tongues were all over the place. The elders were in a frenzy. While they were trying to bring it back under control, I snuck out a side door and left them with the mess.

I did not know what was wrong with me. I could hardly walk. I made it to an iron post supporting the church and grabbed hold of it, hugging it. I could have been arrested for drunk walking.

I was crying like a little baby.

You have to understand: all of my born-again Holy Ghost life, there had been a call on me. No one could tell me how to walk into the power of God. They gave me generalities, but here God had just finished using me.

I knew me: failure, Dave Roberson. Yet He had used my hands and my spirit. I was bawling like a baby.

What kind of God is He to use someone such as us?

All of a sudden, prophecy began to flow. I did not have enough sense to speak it out loud, but He said to me:

"Son, the reason this anointing came on you was not because it was predestinated for this service, nor because you are called to be an evangelist, nor because of creed or race. That anointing came on you because you have uncovered a spiritual law that gives you an ironclad guarantee to build yourself up above a sense-dominated walk, where your senses hold you at bay and bring you to a dead standstill, into a vibrant, Spirit-charged, free walk in the Holy Ghost."

I did not know what was happening then, but I do now. In five nights, I can give you the first step.

One year from that day, my car was an old 1958 Chevrolet, and believe me, it was not 1958. It was 1971.

It smoked so badly that I got stopped six times by the state police in a 150-mile drive to see what was in the smoke screen. I bought my tires at the junkyard for four dollars apiece on the rim. I called them cords. As long as the cord was showing, I could get them for four dollars apiece.

It had 160,000 miles on it when the speedometer broke, and that was before I got it. It was one of those things they give to you if you get it out of the yard.

I carried reclaimed oil. Reclaimed oil is oil somebody else used, then they clean it up, and you get it. The car burned so much oil that I would wait until the red light came on, then jump out and pour in another gallon. Otherwise I would be stopping all the time.

I started preaching, and people felt sorry for me. So they gave me a suit, but the trouble is, five different people gave it to me. Bright red pants, a bright plaid blue sport coat, green shirt, gold tie. I could hear people whispering.

It matched our house. It did not do any good to pull the curtains. If you did not want to be home, people could just see you through the wall. It was on a riverbed, and it shifted and cracked the house. How do you fix a twisted house?

We did not like being humble.

Then somebody gave me some Hagin tapes.

One year from the day I got that tape, one year from the day I started praying in the Holy Ghost, something happened to the Word that was in me.

Let me give you the expression in the natural realm of what happened to me in the spiritual realm.

Parked out in front of our first two-story house, with the down payment made, was a 27-foot Escapade motorhome with a full power plant in it. I owned every bolt in it. It had 4,000 miles on it.

Parked next to it was a brand-new Volkswagen van off the showroom floor. I want you to know I bawled when I slid into that thing while they moved the other cars out of the way so I could drive it off. I got drunk smelling the new upholstery, and I owned every bolt in it.

Parked next to the Volkswagen van, off the Portland docks straight from Germany, was a bright yellow Volkswagen Beetle for my wife's personal car. Inside was the title. We owned every bolt in it.

Twelve months.

What happened? Step two tomorrow night.

It has been my experience that the more a person prays in tongues, the more it charges the Word he already knows.